

For long, surveys had deemed this region crucial, but unsuited for the railways. In his book *Permanent Way Through the Khyber*, British engineer Victor Bayley recounted a conversation between an unnamed commander-in-chief and the Viceroy of India: "Give me two Army Corps and a railway behind me and I'll defy the whole of Asia, and Europe too ... But ... a railway up to this position is impossible!" ... "Until in the fullness of time," continued Bayley who had been assigned to construct the line, "came the Great War, the downfall of Russia, the war with Afghanistan, the military occupation of the Khyber and finally the genius of an engineer who in one brief season destroyed the myth of impossibility, and demonstrated ... that a broad-gauge train could just be got to climb to the summit of the Pass and down again". It took five years to make that vision a reality.

Surveying the territory

The line would have to run through "Tribal Territory" – a buffer between British India and Afghanistan – that had its own set of rules. The tribes were not answerable to British law and considered the railways "forbidden". After the Third Anglo-Afghan War in 1919, it was now even more important to build a line through; fortunately, technology had made some progress by this time. A railway system now connected Peshawar – there was a bridge over River Indus at Attock, and the North Western Railway extended into Jamrud (both in modern-day Pakistan), near the entrance to the Khyber. Colonel GR Hearn – the genius engineer of Bayley's account – conducted an extensive survey of the region to identify the best route for a line.